

The Agricultural Workforce Working Group (the Working Group) met for the final time on 15 September 2023.

Members discussed housing as a critical enabler of attracting and retaining workers in rural, regional and remote Australia. Members endorsed a submission to the Minister for Housing, the Hon Julie Collins MP, recommending place-based approaches and coordinated action across all levels of government alongside private investment to support the availability and suitability of fit-for-purpose housing and accommodation for rural, regional and remote workers, including workers in agriculture and its processing sectors.

Members noted the update from the Department of Employment and Workplace Relations on the proposal to consider the ratification of the International Labour Organization Labour Inspection (Agriculture) Convention in 2024. The proposed ratification will be further considered by the Joint Standing Committee on Treaties.

Members received a presentation from the Minister for Skills and Training, the Hon Brendan O'Connor MP, on key initiatives being progressed in his portfolio including fee-free TAFE, with over 9,500 enrolments in agriculture related courses across the first half of 2023.

Minister O'Connor also announced that Jobs and Skills Australia will deliver a food supply chain capacity study as part of its work plan for 2023-24. Members welcomed the announcement of the capacity study and noted it will make a critical contribution to informing how Australia's training, higher education, and migration systems can best work together to meet the sector's future workforce needs.

Members reflected on the substantive contribution to agricultural workforce issues that would not have occurred without the Working Group, including:

- influential advocacy for fee-free TAFE courses in agriculture, the Food Supply Chain Capacity Study, and the Ag Trade Apprenticeship Project;
- rebuilding and streamlining overseas worker arrivals;
- employer group and union agreement on principles underpinning labour hire licensing;
- representing the needs of the sector in key processes and priorities such as the Migration Review and the Employment White Paper; and
- engaging directly with Ministers in key portfolios affecting the agriculture and processing workforce as well as working with key partners such as Jobs and Skills Australia, Skills Insight, and AgriFutures on relevant initiatives.

Members also reflected on the value of the Working Group's collaborative way of working and endorsed the proposed approach to continued tripartite engagement through an Agricultural Workforce Forum comprised of employer groups, unions, and the Australian Government.

Members acknowledged the valuable contribution of James Flintoft and various officials from the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and expressed appreciation for their efforts and insights in facilitating the Agricultural Workforce Working Group.

Attendees

- Senator the Hon. Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- Patrick Hutchinson, Chief Executive Officer, Australian Meat Industry Council
- Matt Journeaux, Federal Secretary, Australasian Meat Industry Employees Union
- Tony Mahar, Chief Executive Officer, National Farmers' Federation
- Ann Gardiner, National Council member, Australian Dairy Farmers
- Laura Bieniak, Lead Organiser, United Workers Union
- Shane Roulstone, National Organising Director, Australian Workers' Union
- Richard Shannon, Executive Officer, NFF Horticulture Council
- Cindy Briscoe, Acting Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
- James Flintoft, Independent Facilitator
- John Azarias, Special Advisor to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry on Agricultural Workforce Issues

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-workforce-working-group-september-2023>